

Business Analysis Foundations

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1. Summary: What is Business Analysis (BA)?

Business Analysis (BA) is the process of:

- Identifying business needs and problems.
- Understanding and documenting requirements.
- Recommending suitable solutions to improve business outcomes.

A **Business Analyst (BA)** is naturally curious, detail-oriented, and analytical. They constantly observe how things work and ask questions such as:

- What is being done and why?
- Is there a better way to do it?
- Are rules being followed?
- Are the rules still relevant?
- Can the process be more efficient?

Business analysts look beyond everyday activities to understand the reasons behind them. When they notice inefficiencies, inconsistencies, or exceptions, they investigate the root causes and identify opportunities for improvement.

For example, if passengers on an airplane are not boarding according to their assigned boarding groups, a business analyst might ask:

- Why do boarding groups exist?
- Why are the rules not being enforced?
- How do boarding groups relate to seat assignments?
- Is there a more effective boarding process?

Key Takeaway

Business analysis is about **recognizing problems, viewing them as opportunities for improvement, and developing solutions that create value for the business and its stakeholders.**

2. Summary: Business Analysis Industry Definitions

Business Analysis (BA) has existed for more than 30 years, although it has been known by different names and practiced in different ways. Today, industry standards help define and guide BA practices.

Two major organizations provide widely recognized definitions of BA:

1. International Institute of Business Analysis (IIBA)

Definition: Business analysis is the practice of enabling change within an organization by defining needs and recommending solutions that deliver value to stakeholders.

Key emphasis:

- Enabling organizational change.
- Supporting strategic goals.
- Defining business needs.
- Delivering value to stakeholders.

IIBA views BA as a way to help organizations evolve and improve through effective change.

2. Project Management Institute (PMI)

Definition: Business analysis involves applying knowledge, skills, tools, and techniques to identify problems, determine business needs, recommend solutions, manage stakeholder requirements, and support successful implementation of project outcomes.

Key emphasis:

- Understanding and managing stakeholder requirements.
- Supporting project objectives.
- Facilitating successful implementation.
- Delivering products, services, or project results.

PMI sees BA as closely connected to project management and project success.

Comparison

IIBA Focus	PMI Focus

Enabling organizational change	Supporting project success
Business value and strategy	Stakeholder requirements and implementation
Defining needs and recommending solutions	Managing requirements and delivering project outcomes

Key Takeaway

Although definitions vary, the core purpose of Business Analysis remains the same:

Business Analysis seeks to identify and understand business needs and provide solutions that enable change and deliver value.

3. Summary: What is the Role of a Business Analyst?

A **Business Analyst (BA)** is anyone who performs business analysis activities, regardless of their official job title or position. The role can vary depending on:

- Industry type
- Organization size
- Organizational maturity in project management and BA practices
- Project methodology and lifecycle approach

Core Responsibilities

Regardless of where they work, Business Analysts focus on:

- Understanding business needs and problems.
- Aligning solutions with organizational goals and strategy.
- Supporting and enabling change.
- Helping organizations achieve desired outcomes.

Common Activities of a Business Analyst

A BA may:

- Assist in developing new products or improving existing ones.
- Analyze business problems and identify opportunities.
- Recommend and explain solutions.
- Help project teams understand customer and stakeholder needs.
- Communicate the purpose, scope, and benefits of proposed solutions.

Where Business Analysts Work

1. Within the Business Organization

- Help define strategic objectives and future direction.
- Ensure business goals are clearly understood.
- Support organizational planning and decision-making.

2. Within a Project Team

- Act as the bridge between business stakeholders and project teams.
- Define and communicate solution requirements.
- Explain what the solution is, why it is needed, and how it will address business needs.

Business Analyst as a Change Agent

One of the most important modern BA roles is **managing and supporting change**.

Business Analysts:

- Understand the impact of change on people and processes.
- Work with stakeholders across all levels of the organization.
- Help individuals adapt to new ways of working.
- Increase acceptance and adoption of change initiatives.

Value of a Business Analyst

Business Analysts add value by:

- Clearly defining problems and opportunities.
- Linking initiatives to organizational strategy.
- Explaining why projects are selected.
- Improving communication between stakeholders and project teams.
- Supporting successful organizational and project outcomes.

Key Takeaway

A Business Analyst acts as a bridge between business needs and solutions, helping organizations understand problems, support strategic goals, and successfully manage change.

4. Common Business Analyst Skills

4. Summary: Business Analyst Skill Set

A Business Analyst needs a combination of **business knowledge, analytical thinking, communication, and leadership skills**. These skills are useful regardless of the BA's specific role or position.

1. Expert Judgment / Business Acumen

A BA needs a strong understanding of the **organization, industry, and business environment**.

This includes:

- Identifying and comparing alternative solutions.
- Applying previous knowledge and experience.
- Understanding organizational culture.
- Understanding the political environment within an organization.
- Using business knowledge to make informed recommendations.

2. Analytical Skills

Analytical skills help BAs understand complex information and turn it into useful insights.

Key skills include:

- **Critical thinking** – evaluating information logically.
- **Creative thinking** – finding new approaches and solutions.
- **Systems thinking** – understanding how different parts of a business interact.
- **Problem-solving** – identifying problems and developing solutions.
- **Learning skills** – quickly understanding new business areas and information.
- Separating important information from irrelevant details.
- Considering problems from different perspectives.
- Drawing conclusions and supporting decision-making.

3. Communication Skills

Communication is one of the **most important skills for a BA**, because much of their work involves interacting with different stakeholders.

Important communication skills include:

- Facilitation
- Presentation and visualisation
- Active listening
- Writing and documentation
- Understanding non-verbal communication
- Having meaningful conversations with stakeholders
- Collaborating with different teams and individuals

4. Leadership Skills

A BA often acts as a **change agent**, so they need to work confidently with people at different levels of an organization.

This includes:

- Communicating problems and solutions to leaders.
- Explaining the reasoning behind recommendations.
- Influencing stakeholders.
- Working across different departments.
- Guiding people through organizational change.

Key Takeaway

A successful Business Analyst combines **business acumen + analytical thinking + communication + leadership**.

Their natural **curiosity and attention to detail** help them investigate problems, understand different perspectives, identify the right approach, and develop appropriate solutions.

Simple formula:

BA Skills = Business Acumen + Analytical Skills + Communication + Leadership + Curiosity

Summary: Needs Assessment Basics

Needs assessment is the process of identifying and understanding a business need, assessing its impact, and determining an appropriate solution.

Business needs generally fall into **three categories**:

1. **Problems / Improvements** – Existing issues that need to be fixed or processes that could be improved.
2. **Opportunities / New Endeavors** – New possibilities that could help the organization grow or expand.
3. **Compliance Requirements** – Requirements that the organization must meet, such as laws, regulations, or internal policies.

1. Identify the Need

First, the BA needs to clearly understand:

- What problem needs to be solved?
- What improvement should be made?
- What opportunity is being pursued?
- What compliance requirement needs to be addressed?
- What happens if the issue is not addressed?

The BA should understand the **actual need**, rather than immediately jumping to a solution.

2. Assess the Current State

The BA examines the **current state** to understand:

- How the current process works.
- What factors are causing the problem.
- What impact the problem has.
- What resources and constraints currently exist.

However, the BA should avoid **analysis paralysis**—spending too much time analysing the current situation without eventually making a recommendation.

3. Define the Future State

The BA works with the business or customer to understand their desired **future state**.

Then they identify the **gap** between:

Current State → Gap → Future State

If the gap is too large to address in one step, the organization may use an **incremental approach**, implementing smaller changes over time.

4. Gather Supporting Data

The BA collects relevant data to understand the **size and impact** of the problem or opportunity.

This helps determine:

- How serious the problem is.
- How much impact it has on the organization.
- How large the required solution should be.
- How the work should be prioritized.

5. Create a Situation Statement

A **situation statement** describes both the problem/opportunity and its organizational impact.

A useful format is:

The problem or opportunity has the effect of X on the organization, with the resulting impact of Y.

Example:

The existing returns process requires paperwork that duplicates the digital record, resulting in significant delays and additional labour costs. The impact is that additional staff must be hired to meet established quotas.

The situation statement should be reviewed with **key stakeholders** to make sure the BA has correctly understood the situation.

6. Identify Root Causes

BAs can use various techniques to understand why a problem exists, including:

- **Ishikawa Diagram (Fishbone Diagram)** – helps identify and categorize potential root causes.
- **Five Whys** – repeatedly asks “Why?” to identify the underlying cause.
- **Process Flow Models** – visually map a process to identify where problems or inefficiencies occur.

The goal is to address the **real/root problem**, rather than simply treating its symptoms.

7. Develop a Solution

A **solution** is something designed to deliver **measurable business value**.

It could be:

- A new product.
- A new component.
- An enhancement to an existing product.
- A process change.

- A simple fix.

The BA creates a **solution statement** that describes the most viable approach at a high level, including:

- Proposed solution.
- Initial scope.
- Key areas involved.
- Possible steps from the current state to the future state.

8. Consider Multiple Options

A BA should **not provide only one solution**.

Instead, they should develop multiple viable options and allow stakeholders to compare them.

Options can be evaluated using **weighted criteria**, such as:

Criteria	Option A	Option B	Option C
Cost	High	Medium	Low
Time	Fast	Medium	Slow
Technical feasibility	High	High	Medium
Business value	Medium	High	High

A **feasibility study** may also be conducted to evaluate:

- Technical feasibility.
- Operational capability.
- Ability to sustain the change.
- Estimated cost.
- Estimated time.
- Compatibility with the existing environment.

Overall Needs Assessment Process

Identify Need → Assess Current State → Define Future State → Identify Gap → Gather Data → Define Situation → Analyse Root Cause → Develop Multiple Solutions → Assess Feasibility → Recommend Solution

Key Takeaway

Needs assessment helps a Business Analyst understand the real business problem or opportunity, determine its impact, identify the gap between the current and desired states, and recommend viable solutions that deliver measurable business value.

Summary: Stakeholders

1. Who Are Stakeholders?

A **stakeholder** is any individual, group, or organization that:

- May be affected by a project or its outcome.
- Believes they may be affected.
- Can influence a decision, activity, or outcome.

Stakeholders are not limited to people who directly use or benefit from the solution. They can also be people or organizations that **affect the project**.

Examples of Stakeholders

Stakeholders may include:

- People who proposed the project.
- People who will benefit from the solution.
- People with knowledge of the current situation.
- Users of the solution.
- People responsible for implementing or supporting the solution.
- Executives and management.
- Regulatory bodies.
- Internal departments such as purchasing.
- External organizations affected by the project.

Example:

A construction project may notify nearby residents about noise and road closures. However, residents with solar panels may also be affected because construction dust can dirty their panels. They are therefore stakeholders, even though the project team may not have initially considered them.

Key Point

A BA needs to identify both who the project will impact and who can impact the project.

2. Classifying Stakeholders

Not every stakeholder has the same level of influence or interest. A BA needs to assess stakeholders to determine **who is important and how they should be involved**.

A common tool is the **Power/Interest Grid**.

	Low Interest	High Interest
High Power	Executives / senior management	Key stakeholders — require high attention
Low Power	Low-priority stakeholders	People directly affected by the problem

High Power / High Interest

These stakeholders require **significant attention** because they have both influence over the project and strong interest in its outcome.

High Power / Low Interest

Usually executives or senior managers. They may mainly want to understand the **key results, recommendations, and business impact** rather than the detailed analysis.

However, their interests can change, so the BA should continue checking with them.

Low Power / High Interest

These people are often closely involved with the problem or affected by the change. They may have valuable knowledge even though they cannot make major decisions.

Low Power / Low Interest

These stakeholders generally require less attention. However, the BA should still determine whether they have useful information or responsibilities.

3. Assessing Stakeholders

A BA should determine whether each stakeholder can provide what the project needs.

Consider whether they can:

- Provide access to resources.
- Make decisions.
- Provide necessary data.
- Provide knowledge and insights.
- Explain current business activities.
- Help with analysis.
- Support documentation.
- Help implement the solution.

This assessment helps the BA decide **where to spend time and resources**.

4. Engaging Stakeholders

Stakeholder engagement means actively working and communicating with stakeholders throughout the project.

The more stakeholders are involved in developing the solution, the more likely they are to **understand, support, and accept the final result**.

Stakeholder involvement helps them understand:

Why the change is necessary → What the solution will do → How they will be affected

If stakeholders do not understand the reason for change, they may be more likely to **resist the change**.

5. Creating an Engagement Plan

Different stakeholders require different approaches. A BA should develop a **customized engagement plan** for each stakeholder or stakeholder group.

The plan should consider:

Format

How will you communicate?

- Email
- Meetings
- Phone calls

- Presentations

Content

What information do they need?

- High-level summary
- Detailed requirements
- Data and analysis
- Recommendations
- Project status

Timing and Frequency

When and how often should communication occur?

For example:

- Weekly project meetings.
- Monthly executive updates.
- Reviews at key project milestones.

The BA should also understand **why a stakeholder needs specific information and what decision or action it will support**.

6. Continuously Monitor Stakeholders

Stakeholders can change throughout a project.

For example:

- New stakeholders may join.
- Existing stakeholders may leave.
- Someone's level of interest may increase.
- Someone may gain or lose decision-making power.

Therefore, stakeholder engagement should be **continuously monitored and adjusted**.

Key Takeaways

Stakeholder Management Process

Identify → Classify → Assess → Engage → Monitor

A good BA should:

1. **Identify** everyone who may affect or be affected by the project.
2. **Classify** stakeholders based on their power and interest.
3. **Assess** what each stakeholder can contribute.
4. **Engage** them using an appropriate communication approach.
5. **Monitor** their involvement throughout the project.

The goal of stakeholder management is to ensure the right people are involved at the right time, receive the right information, and support the successful delivery of the solution.

Summary: Purpose and Content of a Business Case

1. Purpose of a Business Case

A **Business Case** is a document used to **justify why an organization should invest resources in a project or initiative**.

It helps decision-makers determine whether a proposed project is worth pursuing by comparing the:

Business Need → Proposed Solution → Costs & Resources → Benefits → Risks → Strategic Alignment

The business case is usually prepared by the people requesting the solution and should be proportional to the **size and importance of the project**.

Why is it important?

A Business Case:

- Justifies the resources required for a project.
- Summarizes the findings from the **needs assessment**.
- Explains the business problem or opportunity.
- Identifies the proposed solution.
- Shows expected benefits.
- Compares benefits against costs.
- Ensures the project supports organizational strategy and objectives.
- Provides information for deciding whether to initiate the project.

- Helps prevent **scope creep**, unnecessary costs, delays, and rework.

It is also a **living document**, meaning it should be reviewed and updated when organizational objectives or circumstances change.

For example, if an organization's strategy changes and a project no longer supports its strategic objectives, the project may need to be reconsidered or cancelled.

2. Business Case and Resource Justification

A project may require many different resources, including:

- People
- Equipment
- Supplies
- Funding
- Ongoing support

The organization needs to determine whether the expected **benefits justify the total cost**.

Importantly, cost includes not only the initial development cost but also **ongoing operational and support costs**.

Without a Business Case

If a project is started without properly defining the business need and scope, it may result in:

Unclear need → Scope creep → Cost overruns → Delays → Rework → Solution not being used

The worst outcome is developing something that **does not meet the original business need or stakeholder expectations**.

3. Content of a Business Case

The Business Case has two major components:

A. Business Needs

This section describes **why the project is needed**.

It includes:

- **Situation statement** – the problem or opportunity.
- **Stakeholders** – people or groups affected by or involved in the project.
- **Initial scope** – the high-level boundaries of the proposed project.

B. Previous Analysis of the Situation

This section summarizes information discovered during the needs assessment.

It may include:

- Organizational strategies, goals, and objectives.
- Problem/root-cause analysis.
- Supporting data for an opportunity.
- Critical success factors.
- Gap analysis between current and future capabilities.
- High-level risks.
- Assumptions.
- Constraints.
- Regulatory requirements.
- Alternative implementation options.
- Recommended approaches.
- High-level milestones.
- Dependencies.
- Roles and responsibilities.
- Risks.

4. Measuring Project Benefits

The Business Case needs to demonstrate that the proposed project provides sufficient value.

Common financial and benefit measurement techniques include:

- **Payback Period** – how long it takes to recover the investment.
- **Net Present Value (NPV)** – the present value of future benefits/cash flows minus the investment.
- **Internal Rate of Return (IRR)** – the expected rate of return from the investment.
- **Depreciation** – how the value of an asset decreases over time.
- **Cost-Benefit Analysis** – compares expected costs with expected benefits.
- **Return on Investment (ROI)** – measures the return generated relative to the investment.

The **Finance team** may perform many of these financial calculations, while the **Business Analyst** provides the underlying

business data and analysis.

5. Role of the Business Analyst

The BA contributes to the Business Case by providing information from the **needs assessment and stakeholder analysis**.

The BA works with the **project sponsor and key stakeholders** to understand:

- What business need exists.
- Whether the proposed solution is feasible.
- What benefits can be achieved.
- What risks and constraints exist.
- What factors are critical for success.

Key Takeaway

A Business Case provides a clear justification for starting a project by explaining the business need, proposed solution, expected benefits, required resources, costs, risks, and alignment with organizational objectives.

Simple Business Case Structure

Business Need

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Situation & Root Cause

↓

Stakeholders & Scope

↓

Possible Solutions

↓

Feasibility & Risks

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Costs & Resources

↓

Expected Benefits / ROI

↓

Strategic Alignment

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Recommendation: Proceed / Do Not Proceed

Summary: Project Planning

The transcript covers three important areas of project planning for a **Business Analyst (BA)**: Vision, Project Roadmap, and Responsibilities.

1. Project Planning: Vision

The **project vision** is a clear, idealistic description of the project's desired outcome. It acts like a **thesis statement or goal** that keeps the team focused on the business value behind the project.

Why is the vision important?

It helps the team:

- Understand **why** the project exists.
- Stay focused on the desired business value.
- Understand what the final result should look like.
- Maintain alignment between the project team and stakeholders.
- Stay motivated toward the desired outcome.

The **sponsor, project manager, BA, and key stakeholders** should work together to develop a shared vision.

Vision in the Project Charter

The **Project Charter**, which formally initiates the project, contains the project vision.

The vision should address:

Question	What it describes
Why?	Vision, mission and goals
What?	Objectives and initial scope

Who?	Key internal and external stakeholders
When?	Expected start and end dates
Where?	Location of work or solution deployment
How?	Approach/methodology, such as Agile or Waterfall

Elevator Pitch

The project vision should be **short and easy to understand**, ideally expressed in **one or two statements**.

Everyone involved should be able to quickly explain:

Why does this project exist, and what will it achieve?

The vision should also be reviewed regularly to ensure everyone continues to share the same understanding.

Key Point

A project vision provides a concise description of why the project exists and what it aims to achieve.

2. Project Planning: Project Roadmap

A **project roadmap** is a high-level, chronological view of how a project is expected to progress.

It shows:

- Major milestones.
- Expected delivery of features and functions.
- Dependencies between major activities.
- Resource requirements.
- Expected benefits and results.
- Current progress.
- What is coming next.

Why is a roadmap useful?

It provides **transparency** so that stakeholders and team members can easily understand:

Where we are → Where we've been → Where we're going

It is particularly useful for:

- Large projects.
- Programs.
- Agile/adaptive projects.
- Projects where priorities may change.
- Projects that deliver value incrementally.

Roadmap vs Project Schedule

Project Roadmap	Project Schedule
High-level	Detailed
Communication tool	Planning tool
Shows major milestones	Shows detailed activities
Shows expected delivery timeframes	Helps manage specific tasks
Easier for stakeholders to understand	Mainly used for detailed project planning

The roadmap can initially be created at a **high level** and gradually become more detailed as the project start date approaches.

This is particularly useful in **adaptive projects**, because the future is uncertain and plans may need to change as more information becomes available.

Key Point

A project roadmap communicates the high-level timing, milestones, dependencies, and expected delivery of project benefits and results.

3. Project Planning: Responsibilities

The **Project Manager (PM)** and **Business Analyst (BA)** have different but complementary responsibilities.

There are two types of scope:

Project Scope

The **Project Manager** is primarily responsible for the **project scope**.

It covers:

All the work and deliverables required to complete the project.

Product Scope

The **Business Analyst** is primarily responsible for the **product scope**.
It covers:

The features and functions that the solution needs to provide.

PM vs BA

Project Manager	Business Analyst
Project scope	Product scope
Project deliverables	Product features/functions
Manages project work	Manages requirements
Focuses on delivering the project	Focuses on delivering the right solution

4. Shared Responsibilities

Some activities are performed jointly by the PM and BA, including:

- Identifying stakeholders.
- Analysing stakeholders.
- Planning project activities.
- Coordinating activities between team members.

The BA provides the PM with the activities required for:

1. **Eliciting requirements**
2. **Analysing requirements**
3. **Evaluating requirements**
4. **Tracing requirements**
5. **Verifying requirements**
6. **Validating requirements**

The BA then uses this information to develop the **Business Analysis Plan**.

5. Business Analysis Plan

The **Business Analysis Plan** is an important component of the overall **Project Management Plan**.

It defines:

- Business analysis activities.
- Business analysis deliverables.
- How requirements will be managed.
- How requirements will be traced, verified and validated.

The specific activities depend on the project's approach, such as **predictive** or **adaptive**.

6. BA Responsibilities in Adaptive/Agile Projects

In an **adaptive/Agile approach**, BA activities often occur before release or iteration planning.

The BA focuses on:

- Understanding stakeholder/product owner requirements.
- Identifying exceptions and special cases.
- Prioritising requirements.
- Analysing requirements that provide the most business value.
- Adding requirements to the **requirements baseline or release/iteration backlog**.
- Tracking requirements through completion and approval.

Formal documentation may be lighter in an adaptive environment, but requirements still need to be properly understood and tracked.

Requirement Tracking

The BA may use tools such as:

- **Traceability Matrix**
- Kanban board
- Task board
- Backlog

These help ensure that requirements are:

Identified → Implemented → Completed → Verified → Approved

Overall Key Takeaway

Project planning helps ensure that everyone understands **what the project is trying to achieve, how it will progress, and who is responsible for what.**

Simple Process

Project Vision



Defines **why and what**

Project Roadmap



Defines **when and how progress/delivery will occur**

Responsibilities



Defines **who manages the project and requirements**

Business Analysis Plan



Defines **how requirements will be elicited, analysed, tracked, verified and validated**

Most Important BA Concept

The Project Manager focuses on delivering the project, while the Business Analyst focuses on ensuring the project delivers the right product or solution to meet the business need.

Summary: Determining Requirements

Requirements describe what is needed to satisfy the customer or business need. They often start as a **wish list**, so the BA must analyse, interpret, prioritise, and select the requirements that provide the greatest value.

1. Types of Requirements

There are **six major categories** of requirements:

Requirement Type	Description	Example
Business requirements	High-level organizational needs that explain why the project exists	Reduce customer waiting time
Stakeholder requirements	Needs of specific individuals or stakeholder groups	Customer needs online account access
Solution requirements	Features and characteristics of the final solution	An app must allow customers to pay bills
Transition requirements	Requirements needed to move from the current state to the future state	Staff training and data migration
Project requirements	Requirements related to managing and completing the project	Status reports and project reviews
Quality requirements	Conditions used to determine whether the solution meets required quality levels	Security, reliability, performance

Solution Requirements

Solution requirements have two important subcategories:

Functional requirements

- Describe **what the system/user can do**.
- Example: An online shopping system can process orders and returns.

Non-functional requirements

- Describe **how well the system should operate** or conditions it must meet.
- Examples:
 - Security
 - Performance
 - Reliability
 - Technology requirements

2. Requirements Elicitation

Requirements elicitation is the process of gathering information from stakeholders to understand what they actually need.

The BA should choose techniques based on the situation and stakeholders.

Common Elicitation Techniques

1. Facilitated Workshops

A facilitator guides a group discussion.

Useful because:

- Multiple stakeholders can participate.
- Cross-functional teams can identify gaps and conflicts.
- Encourages brainstorming.
- Helps build communication and consensus.
- Can be used iteratively throughout a project.

2. Interviews

Interviews can be:

- **Structured** – predefined questions.
- **Semi-structured** – prepared questions with follow-up questions.
- **Unstructured** – natural conversation.

They are particularly useful when:

- Information is confidential or sensitive.
- Speaking with senior managers.
- Detailed individual perspectives are required.

3. Document Analysis

The BA reviews existing documentation, processes, and procedures.

An important question is:

Why does this information or process exist?

The fact that something has “always been done that way” does not necessarily mean it is still needed.

4. Observation / Shadowing

The BA observes people performing their actual work.

This can reveal:

- Differences between documented processes and actual practices.
- Unwritten procedures.
- Inefficiencies.
- Problems that stakeholders may not mention during interviews.

5. Questionnaires and Surveys

Useful when there are **large numbers of stakeholders**.

Open-ended questions can provide more detailed information but require more time to analyse.

Choosing an Elicitation Technique

The BA should consider:

- Type of project.
- Project approach, such as Agile or Waterfall.
- Time and budget.
- Number of stakeholders.
- Stakeholder locations.
- Level of detail required.
- Type of requirements documentation needed.

Important

Requirements elicitation should be **thorough but controlled**. Avoid **analysis paralysis**.

The transcript recommends two broad phases:

1. **Initial elicitation** during needs assessment.
2. **Further discovery** after the project begins.

This makes requirements discovery an **iterative process**.

3. Requirements Modelling

After gathering requirements, the BA needs to **analyse and understand them**.

One useful approach is to examine requirements from three perspectives:

Nouns + Verbs + Rules

A. Process Model — Verbs

The **verbs** describe the activities or actions that need to happen.

Example:

“Customer wants to **order** a camera.”

Order = verb → process

The BA maps out the sequence of activities involved in completing the process.

B. Data Model — Nouns

The **nouns** represent the data, objects, or entities involved.

Example:

“Customer wants to order a **camera**.”

Customer and **camera** = nouns → data/entities

The BA identifies things such as:

- Different types of customers.
- Different types of cameras.
- Products.
- Customer information.

C. Business Rule Model — Rules

Business rules describe the **conditions and relationships** that determine how the process operates.

For example:

- Different customer types may receive different discounts.
- Different cameras may have different prices.
- Certain customers may follow different ordering processes.

4. Combining the Models

The real value comes from connecting the three models:

Process Model

→ What activities happen?

Data Model

→ What information/products are involved?

Business Rules

→ What rules determine how those activities work?

For example:

Customer → selects → **Camera** → price determined by → **Customer type / product type**

Even incomplete models or simple sketches can help the BA understand the requirements.

Overall Requirements Process

A useful way to remember the process is:

Gather Requirements

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Analyse & Prioritise

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Model Requirements

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Define Selected Requirements

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Trace & Manage Requirements

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Validate the Solution

Key Takeaway

The BA's job is not simply to collect what the customer asks for. The BA must understand the underlying need, analyse and prioritise requirements, model the processes, data and business rules, and select requirements that deliver the greatest business value while controlling project scope.

Summary: **Traceability** Matrix, Task Board & Change Control

1. Traceability Approach

A **traceability approach** defines how requirements will be related, tracked, and monitored throughout a project. It allows the team to:

- Connect requirements to business/project objectives.
- Track the progress of individual requirements.
- Identify requirements that are blocked or delayed.
- Take action to remove obstacles.
- Ensure requirements are eventually **implemented and approved**.

The BA determines the appropriate traceability approach as part of the **Business Analysis Plan**.

2. Traceability Matrix

A **Requirements Traceability Matrix (RTM)** is a tool used to track requirements throughout the project.

It can connect:

Business Objectives → Features/Epics → User Stories/Requirements → Design → Development → Testing → Acceptance

A detailed traceability matrix may contain links to:

- Use cases.
- Analysis models.
- Design documents.
- Test plans.
- Test cases and results.
- Acceptance/sign-off records.
- Business and project objectives.

Why is it important?

The traceability matrix acts as a **central hub or single source of information** for requirements.

It helps the BA:

- Track requirement status.
- Confirm that requirements are implemented.
- Confirm requirements have been tested.
- Confirm stakeholder approval.
- Understand the impact of requirement changes.
- Assess changes in terms of **cost, time, risk, and scope**.
- Improve communication between project participants.

Example

Requirement	Objective	Status	Test Case	Approval
User can reset password	Improve account accessibility	Done	TC-01	Approved
User can view data usage	Improve customer self-service	In Progress	TC-02	Pending
User can pay bill online	Improve payment experience	To Do	TC-03	Pending

The amount of detail should depend on the project's **size, complexity, and importance**.

3. Task Board / Kanban Board

A **task board** is a visual way to show the current status of work.

A simple board might contain:

To Do → In Progress → Done

The **In Progress** column can be divided further:

Analysis → Design → Development → Testing → Done

Requirements or tasks can be represented by cards/sticky notes and moved between columns as work progresses.

Task Board vs Traceability Matrix

Task Board	Traceability Matrix
Mainly visual	Digital documentation
Shows work status	Tracks requirements and relationships
Simple and easy to understand	More comprehensive

Focuses on progress	Connects requirements to objectives, documents and tests
Useful for daily team work	Acts as a central requirements hub

They can be used **together**. The task board shows progress visually, while the traceability matrix provides the more complete record.

4. Change Control

Change control is the process of managing changes to requirements, scope, plans, or other project elements.

The BA should **not simply accept or reject every change request**.

Instead, the BA helps determine:

- What is being changed?
- Why is the change needed?
- What impact will it have?
- How important is the change?
- What are the effects on scope, cost, time, and risk?
- Should the change be implemented now or later?

Typical Change Control Process

Change Request

↓

Log the Request

↓

Analyse Impact

↓

Assess Importance & Risk

↓

Approve / Reject / Defer

↓

Update Requirements & Plans

↓

Implement & Track Change

All change requests should be **received and recorded**, regardless of where they come from.

5. Change Control Board (CCB)

Major changes may require approval from a **Change Control Board (CCB)** or **Steering Committee**.

However, **not every change needs to go to the CCB**.

The organization should define which changes can be approved by:

- Business Analyst.
- Project Manager.
- Project Sponsor.
- Change Control Board / Steering Committee.

The required approval level depends on the **size and impact of the change**.

6. Managing Change Through Smaller Deliverables

One way to handle frequent changes is to divide a large project into **smaller portions**.

Instead of trying to plan everything at once:

Large Project → Smaller Deliverables → Review → Adapt → Next Deliverable

This makes it easier to:

- Plan accurately.
- Deliver value earlier.
- Respond to new information.
- Incorporate changes into future work.

This approach is particularly useful in **Agile/adaptive projects**.

7. Configuration Control

Change management also involves **configuration control**, which means tracking changes to documents, processes, and other project artifacts through **version control**.

For example:

Requirements v1.0 → Requirements v1.1 → Requirements v2.0

The purpose is to ensure:

- Everyone knows when something has changed.
- Everyone is using the latest version.
- Previous versions can be identified when necessary.
- Changes are properly documented.

Key Takeaways

Traceability

Traceability ensures that requirements can be followed from their original business objective through implementation, testing, and approval.

Task Board

A task board provides a simple visual representation of work progress.

Traceability Matrix

The traceability matrix is the central hub connecting requirements with objectives, documentation, development, testing, and approval.

Change Control

Change control ensures that changes are analysed for their impact before being approved, rejected, or deferred.

Simple BA Workflow

Business Objective

↓

Requirement

↓

Trace & Track

↓

Design / Development

↓

Testing

↓

Approval

If a change occurs:

Change Request → Impact Analysis → Decision → Update Traceability → Implement → Verify

Summary: Evaluating the Solution

Evaluating a solution involves **verifying and validating requirements and the final result** to ensure that the solution has been built correctly and actually meets stakeholder needs.

1. Testing and Verifying Requirements

Verification

Verification checks whether the solution **conforms to the specifications and requirements** that were defined.

In simple terms:

Did we build the solution correctly according to the requirements?

Requirements should be verified continuously throughout the project.

Initial Verification

The BA works with stakeholders to confirm that:

- Requirements accurately represent stakeholder needs.
- Requirements are clear and complete.
- Enough detail has been provided to developers.
- Appropriate **acceptance criteria** have been defined.

This can happen during:

- Needs assessment.
- Review of the situation statement.
- Review of the solution statement.

- Requirements discussions.

Predictive vs Adaptive Approaches

Predictive Approach	Adaptive Approach
More formal	More collaborative
Requirements specification documents	Conversations and modelling
Formal requirement reviews	Continuous discussions
Requirements reviewed before implementation	Requirements evolve through iterations

2. Testing the Developed Solution

Once a requirement has been implemented, the result needs to be tested to verify that it meets the defined specification.

Testing may include different levels of testing depending on the organization's development methodology and **Quality Management Plan**.

The BA may help with:

- Planning testing activities.
- Identifying test scenarios/scripts.
- Identifying test data.
- Linking test results to requirements.

The **traceability matrix** can be used to record:

Requirement → Test Case → Test Result

This provides evidence that requirements have been tested.

3. Cost of Quality

Testing requires time and resources, so the organization needs to determine **how much testing is appropriate**.

This is related to the concept of **Cost of Quality**, which considers activities used to:

- Prevent problems.
- Assess quality.
- Identify non-conformance or failures.

There is also a **law of diminishing returns**.

In other words:

More testing does not always provide proportionally more value.

The goal is to perform **enough testing to achieve an appropriate level of quality**, rather than testing indefinitely.

4. Validating the Requirements

After verification, the final result must be **validated and accepted**.

Validation

Validation determines whether the result:

1. Meets the defined **acceptance criteria**.
2. Actually meets the **needs of the stakeholder**.

In simple terms:

Did we build the right solution?

5. Verification vs Validation

This is an important distinction:

Verification	Validation
Checks against specifications	Checks against stakeholder needs
"Did we build it correctly?"	"Did we build the right thing?"
Focuses on requirements/conformance	Focuses on acceptance and business need
Usually involves testing	Usually involves stakeholder acceptance

Example

Requirement:

"Customers must be able to view their remaining mobile data."

Verification:

Does the app correctly display the customer's remaining data according to the specification?

Validation:

Does the feature actually provide customers with the information they need and meet the agreed acceptance criteria?

6. Acceptance Criteria

Acceptance criteria define the conditions that must be satisfied before a requirement can be accepted.

They should ideally be considered when the requirement or user story is first created.

However, the most effective approach is **continuous discussion** between:

- Business Analyst
- Developer/implementation team
- Stakeholder

This ensures everyone has the same understanding of what “accepted” means.

7. RACI / Responsibility Matrix

A **RACI responsibility matrix** can help identify who is responsible for approving each requirement.

RACI generally represents:

- **R – Responsible:** Performs the work.
- **A – Accountable:** Ultimately responsible for approval/outcome.
- **C – Consulted:** Provides input.
- **I – Informed:** Kept informed.

For requirements validation, it helps identify:

- Who approves the requirement.
- Who should be consulted.
- Who needs to be informed about the approval status.

8. Traceability Matrix and Acceptance

The **traceability matrix** is particularly important at the end of the project.

It helps ensure that every requirement has been:

Defined → Implemented → Tested → Validated → Accepted

It can also reveal missing acceptance criteria or requirements that have not yet been approved.

Overall Solution Evaluation Process

Define Requirements

↓

Verify Requirements

↓

Develop Solution

↓

Test Solution

↓

Verify Against Specifications

↓

Validate Against Stakeholder Needs

↓

Stakeholder Acceptance

↓

Complete Requirement

Key Takeaway

Verification checks whether the solution was built according to the requirements, while validation confirms that the solution actually meets the stakeholder's needs and acceptance criteria.

For a Business Analyst, the ultimate goal is not simply to ensure that every requirement was implemented—it is to ensure that the **final solution provides the intended business value and solves the original problem.**

Summary: Project Release, Transition & Implementation Planning

These three planning activities focus on **how the completed solution is delivered, introduced into the organization, and supported after implementation.**

1. Project Release Planning

A **release** is the product, service, result, or solution being delivered to the customer.

Release planning determines:

What will be delivered + When it will be delivered

Release planning starts early, often when the **project roadmap** is created.

Key considerations

The BA and team need to determine:

- What should be delivered?
- When should it be delivered?
- Can the solution be delivered in stages?
- Which stage should be delivered first?
- Who is receiving the solution?
- Which requirements provide the most value?
- Which requirements are feasible to deliver first?

Requirements are grouped or **“chunked” into releases** according to priority, feasibility, and value.

Example

Suppose a company wants to start selling products in France.

The release plan might need to prioritise:

1. French website.
2. French language support.
3. GDPR compliance.
4. Payment functionality.
5. Local branding.
6. Physical office requirements, if necessary.

Not everything can necessarily be delivered at once, so the BA needs to determine what is most important.

Release Planning vs Sprint Planning

Release Planning	Sprint Planning
High-level	Detailed
Plans releases	Plans individual sprints
Longer timeframe	Shorter, time-boxed timeframe
Groups requirements into releases	Selects specific work for a sprint
Focuses on major outcomes	Focuses on concrete tasks/user stories

Both rely heavily on **prioritisation**.

Big Rocks Analogy

Imagine filling a jar with:

- Big rocks = high-priority requirements
- Small rocks = medium-priority requirements
- Sand = low-priority requirements

If you put the sand in first, there may not be enough room for the big rocks.

Therefore:

Put the big rocks in first.

The highest-value and highest-priority requirements should be addressed first.

2. Project Transition Planning

The **Transition Plan** describes **how the completed solution will be introduced into the organization**.

A useful distinction is:

Release Plan = What and when

Transition Plan = How the solution will be introduced

Transition activities may include:

- Staff training.
- Documentation.
- Data conversion/migration.
- Pilot programs

- Pilot programs.
- Communication.
- Deployment activities.
- Translating documentation.
- Support arrangements.

Without transition planning, the project team could simply deliver the product and leave the organization to figure out how to use it.

Transition Approaches

1. Pilot

The solution is introduced to a **small group or test market first**.

This allows the organization to:

- Identify problems.
- Gather feedback.
- Make adjustments.
- Test acceptance before wider deployment.

2. Parallel Operation

The **old and new systems operate simultaneously** for a period of time.

This is useful when accuracy is particularly important.

For example, a financial organization might run the old and new systems together and compare their results.

Advantage: Lower risk.

Disadvantage: Requires additional resources and effort.

3. Big Bang

The old system is completely replaced by the new system at once.

Advantage: Fast transition.

Disadvantage: High risk and extensive preparation/testing are required.

Usually, there is limited or no opportunity to return to the previous system.

3. Training and Documentation

Transition planning should not only consider training existing employees.

The organization should also consider:

How will new employees be trained after the project team has left?

Possible approaches include:

- Training before implementation.
- Updated user documentation.
- Quick-start guides.
- Train-the-trainer programs.
- Ongoing onboarding materials.

This ensures that knowledge remains within the organization.

4. Solution Implementation Planning

After the solution is released, the **Business Analyst continues to work with the receiving organization** to make sure the solution is actually being used and delivering the expected results.

This is important because:

A solution can be technically complete and accepted but still fail to achieve the desired business outcome.

Users may resist the change or have difficulty adapting to the new way of working.

BA's Role After Implementation

The BA may:

- Observe users through **shadowing**.
- Check how the solution is actually being used.
- Identify problems or unexpected issues.
- Identify resistance to change.
- Identify additional requirements.
- Recommend future improvements.
- Check whether expected business benefits are being achieved.

The BA should recognise that the initial solution may only solve **part of the original problem**. Further improvements may become future projects or enhancements.

become future projects or enhancements.

5. Ongoing Support

After implementation, the organization may need a dedicated **support team**.

For example, after implementing new software, the organization may need:

- Help desk support.
- Technical support.
- Business support.
- Additional funding.
- Support documentation.
- Training materials.
- Ongoing staff resources.

The BA can help establish the support team and provide them with information about the solution.

6. Tracking Business Results

Implementation doesn't end when the system goes live.

The organization needs to track whether the expected results are actually being achieved.

For example:

Expected: Customer service response time decreases from 24 hours to 4 hours.

After implementation, the BA may monitor:

Actual response time → Compare with target → Identify gaps → Recommend improvements

Tracking and reporting should ideally be planned as part of the **transition and implementation plans**.

Overall Process

The three planning activities can be understood as:

Release Planning

What + When?

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Transition Planning

How do we introduce it?

↓

Implementation Planning

How do we ensure it is adopted, supported and delivering value?

Key Takeaway

Release planning determines what will be delivered and when; transition planning determines how the solution will be introduced to the organization; and implementation planning ensures that the solution is adopted, supported, measured, and improved after delivery.

BA's End-to-End Responsibility

Business Need

↓

Requirements

↓

Solution Development

↓

Release

↓

Transition

↓

Implementation & Adoption

↓

Measure Results

↓

Identify Future Improvements

The important BA mindset is that **delivery is not the end of the job**. The ultimate goal is to make sure the solution creates the intended **business value** and successfully moves the organization from the **current state to the desired future state**.